

Physiotherapy letter

NHS COMMUNITY MUSCULOSKELETAL PHYSIOTHERAPY SERVICE

Central Health Centre

45 Wellington Road

Anytown

AB1 4EF

Telephone: 01234 678910

Date: 12 March 2026

Private and Confidential

Dr Sarah Williams

Riverside Medical Practice

123 High Street

Anytown

AB1 2CD

Dear Dr Williams,

Re: Michael Thompson

DOB: 14 June 1965

NHS Number: 987 654 3210 (Fictional)

Thank you for referring Mr Thompson to the Musculoskeletal Physiotherapy Service for assessment and management of his longstanding back pain and osteoarthritis.

Mr Thompson attended his physiotherapy assessment today accompanied by his partner.

History

Mr Thompson reports a long history of chronic low back pain, which has been present for approximately thirteen years. He describes constant aching pain across the lower lumbar region with intermittent radiating pain into the left leg, particularly during periods of increased activity.

He also reports osteoarthritis affecting both knees, both shoulders and both hands. Symptoms have gradually worsened over recent years and are impacting on his day-to-day function. He reports difficulty with walking, prolonged standing, stair climbing, bending, reaching overhead and tasks requiring grip strength.

The claimant reports that joint stiffness is most pronounced in the mornings and following periods of inactivity. He advises that symptoms can take up to one hour to ease after waking.

Current Functional Difficulties

Mr Thompson reports the following difficulties:

- Walking limited by pain in the lower back and knees.
- Increased pain when standing for prolonged periods.
- Difficulty preparing meals due to reduced grip strength and hand pain.
- Difficulty bending to put on socks and shoes.

- Difficulty carrying shopping.
- Difficulty climbing stairs due to knee pain and breathlessness.
- Requirement for frequent rest periods during household activities.
- Reliance on a walking stick when outdoors.

The claimant reports that on bad days he spends much of the day seated and limits activities to essential tasks only.

Examination Findings

On assessment, Mr Thompson demonstrated:

- Reduced lumbar spine range of movement in all directions.
- Pain on forward flexion of the lumbar spine.
- Reduced range of movement in both shoulders.
- Reduced grip strength bilaterally.
- Crepitus and pain affecting both knees during movement.
- Slow and cautious gait pattern.
- Reduced tolerance for repeated functional movements.

No acute neurological deficits were identified during assessment.

Clinical Impression

The clinical findings are consistent with chronic mechanical low back pain with degenerative changes together with multi-site osteoarthritis affecting the knees, shoulders and hands.

Symptoms appear longstanding and are likely to fluctuate in severity; however, overall functional ability has reduced compared with previous reports. Pain, stiffness and reduced mobility continue to have a significant impact upon activities of daily living and community mobility.

Treatment Plan

The following advice and interventions were discussed:

- Joint protection techniques.
- Activity pacing strategies.
- Gentle home exercise programme.
- Maintenance of mobility within pain limits.
- Advice regarding posture and movement.
- Continued use of walking aid as required.

Given the chronic nature of Mr Thompson's conditions, treatment is focused upon symptom management, maintaining function and preventing further decline rather than complete resolution of symptoms.

Prognosis

Mr Thompson presents with long-term degenerative musculoskeletal conditions. Significant improvement is not anticipated in the short term. Ongoing symptoms affecting mobility, functional activities and manual tasks are likely to persist despite appropriate management.

Summary

Mr Thompson continues to experience substantial functional limitations arising from chronic back pain and osteoarthritis. He demonstrates reduced mobility, reduced grip strength and difficulty completing a range of daily activities without pain and fatigue. These difficulties appear consistent with the clinical findings observed during assessment.

Please feel free to contact the department if you require any further information.

Yours sincerely,

Emma Richardson

Senior Musculoskeletal Physiotherapist

HCPC Registration Number: PH987654 (Fictional)

NHS Community Musculoskeletal Physiotherapy Service

Cc: Michael Thompson